

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE

Website Build, Deployment & Client Delivery

Version 1.0 — The Analyst Agenda

OVERVIEW

This SOP covers the complete workflow for building, testing, deploying, and handing over a professional website to a client using free tools and Claude Code via VS Code. Websites built under this procedure are production-ready, SEO-aware out of the box, and designed for zero ongoing maintenance cost to the client. Google Ads management and advanced SEO optimisation are available as paid upsells.

Estimated time per project: 4–12 hours depending on site complexity **Skill requirement:** Intermediate comfort with VS Code; no prior coding experience required beyond this SOP

TOOL STACK (ALL FREE)

Tool	Purpose	Where to Get It
VS Code	Code editor	code.visualstudio.com
Claude Code	AI coding assistant	claude.ai/code
Git	Version control	git-scm.com
GitHub	Code hosting & backup	github.com
Vercel	Deployment & hosting	vercel.com
Namecheap / Squarespace DNS	Domain management (client pays)	namecheap.com
Google Search Console	Search visibility	search.google.com/search-console
Google Analytics 4	Traffic tracking	analytics.google.com

Tool	Purpose	Where to Get It
Canva (Free)	Image assets & logos	canva.com
Figma (Free)	Design reference / mockups	figma.com
Notion (Free)	Client briefs, project notes	notion.so
Stripe (Free to set up)	Payment collection	stripe.com

Note on domains: Domains are the client's responsibility (~\$15–25 NZD/year). You facilitate the setup; they own and pay for it. This keeps hosting and maintenance costs at zero for both parties post-handover.

PHASE 1 — CLIENT DISCOVERY & SCOPING

Step 1.1 — Initial Client Meeting

Hold a 30–45 minute call or in-person meeting. Take notes in Notion using the template below.

Discovery Questions to Ask:

- What does your business do, and who is your ideal customer?
- Do you have an existing website? What do you dislike about it?
- Do you have a logo, brand colours, or existing visual assets?
- What are the 3–5 most important things a visitor should be able to do on your site?
- Do you have a Google Business Profile set up?
- Do you have any specific pages in mind? (e.g. Home, About, Services, Contact, Gallery, Bookings)
- What is your timeline?
- Do you have a domain name already, or do you need one?

Step 1.2 — Define the Scope

Standard website packages (suggested):

Package	Pages	Price Guide	Notes
Starter	3–4 pages	\$800–\$1,200 NZD	Home, About, Services, Contact

Package	Pages	Price Guide	Notes
Professional	5–7 pages	\$1,500–\$2,500 NZD	+ Gallery, FAQ, Booking, Blog
Premium	8+ pages	\$3,000+ NZD	Full custom build

Add-on upsells (optional, billed separately):

- Google Ads setup & management: \$200–\$500 NZD/month
- Advanced SEO package: \$300–\$600 NZD one-time
- Monthly performance reporting: \$100–\$200 NZD/month

Step 1.3 — Client Brief Document

Create a Notion page titled [Client Name] – Website Brief with:

Business name:

Industry:

Target audience:

Tone/style: (e.g. professional, friendly, luxurious, bold)

Pages required:

Logo/assets available: Yes / No

Brand colours (hex codes if known):

Reference websites they like:

Domain name (existing or needed):

Deadline:

Payment agreed:

Step 1.4 — Collect a Deposit

Before any work begins, collect 50% of the agreed fee via Stripe payment link.

How to do this:

1. Go to dashboard.stripe.com → Payment Links → Create
 2. Set the amount, add a product name (e.g. "Website Deposit — [Client Name]")
 3. Send the link to the client via email or message
 4. Do not begin work until payment is confirmed
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PHASE 2 — ENVIRONMENT SETUP

Step 2.1 — Install Required Tools

Do this once. Skip steps for tools already installed.

1. **VS Code:** Download from code.visualstudio.com and install
2. **Claude Code:** Install the Claude Code extension from within VS Code (Extensions panel → search "Claude Code") or follow setup at claude.ai/code
3. **Git:** Download from git-scm.com and install. Verify by opening Terminal in VS Code and typing `git --version`
4. **Node.js:** Download from nodejs.org (LTS version). Verify with `node --version`
5. **Vercel CLI:** In VS Code Terminal, run: `npm install -g vercel`

Step 2.2 — Create a GitHub Account

1. Go to github.com and create a free account
2. In VS Code Terminal, run:

```
git config --global user.name "Your Name"
```

```
git config --global user.email "your@email.com"
```

Step 2.3 — Set Up the Project Folder

For each new client project:

1. Create a folder on your Desktop: `[ClientName]-website`
2. Open VS Code → File → Open Folder → select this folder
3. Open the integrated Terminal (Ctrl+ or Cmd+)
4. Initialise a Git repository:

```
git init
```

Step 2.4 — Choose Your Build Framework

For most client websites, use **Next.js** (React-based, Vercel-native, excellent SEO defaults).

Run in Terminal:

```
npx create-next-app@latest . --typescript --tailwind --eslint --app --no-src-dir --import-alias "@/*"
```

When prompted, accept all defaults. This creates a production-ready project structure automatically.

Why Next.js? It renders pages server-side by default, which means search engines can read your content immediately — this is your baseline SEO advantage without any extra work.

PHASE 3 — BUILDING THE WEBSITE WITH CLAUDE CODE

Step 3.1 — Activate Claude Code

1. With your project folder open in VS Code, open the Claude Code panel (sidebar or Ctrl+Shift+P → "Open Claude Code")
2. Sign in with your Anthropic account
3. Claude Code can now read, write, and edit all files in your project

Step 3.2 — Write Your Master Prompt

Before touching any code, write a detailed master prompt for Claude Code. Open a new chat and paste the following template, filled out with your client's details:

You are building a professional website for [Business Name], a [industry/type of business].

BUSINESS CONTEXT:

- Target audience: [who they serve]
- Tone: [professional / friendly / bold / luxurious — pick one]
- Key message: [what the site must communicate above all else]

PAGES REQUIRED:

- Home (hero, services overview, social proof, CTA)
- About (story, team if applicable, values)
- Services (list of services with descriptions)
- Contact (form, phone, address if applicable)

[add additional pages as needed]

DESIGN PREFERENCES:

- Brand colours: [hex codes, or "derive from logo"]
- Reference sites they like: [URLs if provided]
- Logo file: [describe if available, or "create a text-based logo"]

TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS:

- Framework: Next.js with Tailwind CSS
- Mobile-first responsive design
- Fast loading: optimise all images
- SEO-ready: every page must have a unique title tag, meta description, and correct heading hierarchy (one H1 per page)
- Accessible: sufficient colour contrast, alt text on all images
- No placeholder text ("Lorem ipsum") — write real copy based on the business context I've provided

BUILD ORDER:

1. Global layout (header with navigation, footer with contact info and copyright)
2. Home page
3. About page

4. Services page
5. Contact page with working form
6. [additional pages]

Start by creating the project file structure and global layout. Ask me before proceeding to each new page so I can review.

Step 3.3 — Iterative Build Process

Work through pages one at a time:

1. **Tell Claude Code to build one page** — use the prompt above as context, then say "Build the Home page now."
2. **Preview in browser** — in Terminal, run `npm run dev`, then open `http://localhost:3000`
3. **Request changes** — describe what you want adjusted in plain English. Example: "Make the hero section taller, centre the text, and change the button colour to match the brand colour."
4. **Confirm, then move to the next page** — only proceed when the current page looks correct

Step 3.4 — Copy & Content

You have two options:

Option A — Claude writes the copy: Ask Claude Code: "Write professional website copy for the About page. The business is [description]. The tone should be [tone]."

Option B — Client provides copy: Collect copy from the client in a Google Doc or Notion page, then paste it into Claude Code: "Use this copy for the About page: [paste text]. Format it correctly within the existing design."

Step 3.5 — Images & Assets

Use **Canva** (free) to:

- Create a simple logo if the client doesn't have one
- Resize and optimise any photos the client provides
- Export all images as `.webp` format for web performance

Save all images to `/public/images/` in your project folder.

For stock images, use:

- **Unsplash** (unsplash.com) — free, high quality
- **Pexels** (pexels.com) — free, no attribution required
- **StockSnap** (stocksnap.io) — good commercial-use library

When adding images to the project, ask Claude Code: "Add this image `/public/images/hero.webp` to the hero section with appropriate alt text for SEO."

Step 3.6 — Contact Form Setup

For the contact form, use **Formspree** (formspree.io — free up to 50 submissions/month):

1. Sign up at formspree.io with your client's email (or your own, then hand over)
2. Create a new form → copy the endpoint URL
3. Tell Claude Code: "Wire up the contact form to this Formspree endpoint: [URL]. When submitted, show a success message."

This gives the client a working contact form with no backend code and no cost.

PHASE 4 — SEO BASELINE (BUILT INTO EVERY BUILD)

These steps are non-negotiable on every project. They give the site a strong foundation for search visibility without any paid SEO work.

Step 4.1 — Page Titles and Meta Descriptions

Ask Claude Code to generate these for every page:

Generate SEO metadata for every page of this website:

- Page title: 50–60 characters, include primary keyword and business name
- Meta description: 150–160 characters, compelling, include a call to action
- Use Next.js metadata API (export const metadata) in each page file

Example format Claude should produce:

```
export const metadata = {
```


title: "Auckland Plumber | 24/7 Emergency Service | Smith Plumbing",

description: "Auckland's trusted plumber for residential and commercial jobs. Available 24/7. Call Smith Plumbing today for a free quote.",

};

Step 4.2 — Heading Structure

Tell Claude Code: "Ensure every page has exactly one H1 tag containing the primary keyword. Use H2 for major sections and H3 for subsections. Do not skip heading levels."

Step 4.3 — Schema Markup (Local Business)

For local businesses, tell Claude Code:

Add LocalBusiness schema markup to the home page using JSON-LD.

Include: business name, address, phone, opening hours, and website URL.

Use the following details: [fill in client details]

This structured data helps Google display the business in map packs and knowledge panels.

Step 4.4 — Sitemap and robots.txt

Next.js handles sitemaps automatically when deployed to Vercel. Confirm by asking Claude Code: "Add a sitemap.xml and robots.txt to this Next.js project using the App Router conventions."

Step 4.5 — Performance Optimisation

Tell Claude Code:

- "Use `next/image` for all images with appropriate width, height, and alt attributes"
- "Use `next/font` to load any Google Fonts to avoid layout shift"
- "Ensure no unused CSS or JavaScript libraries are imported"

Step 4.6 — Mobile Responsiveness

In the browser preview (`localhost:3000`), use Chrome DevTools (F12 → mobile device toggle) to check:

- All pages render correctly on iPhone SE (375px width)
- Navigation collapses to a mobile menu

- Text is readable without zooming
- Buttons are large enough to tap

Tell Claude Code to fix any layout issues you observe.

PHASE 5 — QUALITY ASSURANCE

Run through this checklist before showing the client anything.

Technical QA Checklist

- ☐ All pages load without console errors (F12 → Console tab, should be empty or only warnings)
- ☐ All navigation links go to the correct pages
- ☐ Contact form submits successfully and a confirmation email arrives at the client's inbox
- ☐ All images load and have alt text
- ☐ Site is fully responsive on mobile (375px), tablet (768px), and desktop (1440px)
- ☐ No placeholder text (Lorem ipsum) anywhere on the site
- ☐ Logo and favicon are in place

SEO QA Checklist

- ☐ Every page has a unique title tag
- ☐ Every page has a unique meta description
- ☐ Every page has exactly one H1
- ☐ All images have descriptive alt text
- ☐ Schema markup is present on home page
- ☐ sitemap.xml accessible at </sitemap.xml>
- ☐ robots.txt accessible at </robots.txt>

Content QA Checklist

- ☐ Business name is spelled correctly throughout
- ☐ Phone numbers and email addresses are correct and clickable on mobile
- ☐ Address is correct (if applicable)
- ☐ Social media links go to the correct profiles
- ☐ Copyright year in footer is current

Performance Check

Run a free Lighthouse audit:

1. Open Chrome → navigate to `localhost:3000`
 2. F12 → Lighthouse tab → Analyse page load
 3. Target scores: Performance 80+, SEO 90+, Accessibility 80+, Best Practices 90+
 4. Fix any critical issues Claude Code identifies
-

PHASE 6 — DEPLOYMENT TO VERCEL

Step 6.1 — Push to GitHub

In VS Code Terminal:

```
git add .
```

```
git commit -m "Initial build complete"
```

1. Go to github.com → New Repository
2. Name it `[clientname]-website` → set to Private → Create
3. Copy the repository URL shown on screen
4. In Terminal:

```
git remote add origin [paste URL here]
```

```
git branch -M main
```

```
git push -u origin main
```

Step 6.2 — Connect Vercel to GitHub

1. Go to vercel.com → Sign up with your GitHub account (free)
2. Click "Add New Project"
3. Select your GitHub repository from the list
4. Vercel auto-detects Next.js — leave all settings as default
5. Click "Deploy"

Vercel will build and deploy the site. This takes 1–3 minutes. You'll get a free preview URL like `clientname-website.vercel.app`.

Step 6.3 — Test the Live Preview URL

Before connecting the client's domain, send the `.vercel.app` URL to the client for approval. This is your staging environment.

Ask the client to:

- Review all pages for accuracy
- Confirm all content is correct
- Test the contact form
- Give written approval to proceed (a WhatsApp or email "looks great, go ahead" is sufficient)

Do not connect the domain or collect final payment until you have this approval.

Step 6.4 — Connect the Custom Domain

Once client approves:

1. In Vercel → Project Settings → Domains → Add Domain
2. Type the client's domain (e.g. `smithplumbing.co.nz`)
3. Vercel shows you DNS records to add (usually an A record and CNAME)
4. Go to wherever the domain is registered (Namecheap, GoDaddy, etc.)
5. Add the DNS records exactly as shown by Vercel
6. DNS propagation takes 10 minutes to 48 hours

Tip: If the client doesn't yet have a domain, direct them to namecheap.com. A `.co.nz` domain costs ~\$20 NZD/year. They purchase it in their own name and give you access to the DNS settings.

Vercel automatically provisions a free SSL certificate (HTTPS). No extra steps required.

PHASE 7 — GOOGLE SETUP (INCLUDED IN EVERY HANDOVER)

This takes 30 minutes and dramatically improves the client's search visibility from day one.

Step 7.1 — Google Search Console

1. Go to search.google.com/search-console

2. Sign in with the client's Google account (ask them to share their screen or do it together)
3. Add Property → Domain → type the domain
4. Verify ownership: Vercel makes this easy — add a TXT record to DNS as shown
5. Submit the sitemap: Sitemaps → enter [https://\[domain\]/sitemap.xml](https://[domain]/sitemap.xml) → Submit

Step 7.2 — Google Analytics 4

1. Go to analytics.google.com → Create Account
2. Set up a property for the client's website
3. Copy the Measurement ID (format: [G-XXXXXXXXXX](#))
4. Tell Claude Code: "Add Google Analytics 4 tracking with Measurement ID [G-XXXXXXXXXX] to this Next.js site using the App Router."
5. Push the update to GitHub → Vercel redeploys automatically
6. Verify by visiting the site and checking Real-Time in Google Analytics

Step 7.3 — Google Business Profile (If Not Already Set Up)

1. Go to business.google.com
2. Create or claim the business listing
3. Add the website URL, phone, hours, and photos
4. Request verification (usually by postcard — takes 5–14 days)

This is one of the highest-leverage actions for local search visibility.

PHASE 8 — CLIENT HANDOVER

Step 8.1 — Transfer GitHub Repository (Optional)

If the client wants full code ownership:

1. Go to GitHub → Repository Settings → Transfer
2. Transfer to the client's GitHub username (they need a free account)
3. Alternatively, invite them as a collaborator so they have access without full ownership

For most small business clients, simply keeping ownership yourself and giving them Vercel dashboard access is sufficient.

Step 8.2 — Transfer Vercel Access

1. In Vercel → Team Settings → Members → Invite the client's email
2. Set role to "Member" so they can view deployments and manage their domain

3. The site stays live and managed under your Vercel account, or you can transfer the project to them

Step 8.3 — Prepare the Handover Document

Create a Google Doc or Notion page titled **[Client Name] – Website Handover Guide**.
Include:

WEBSITE HANDOVER DOCUMENT

Client: [Name]

Website: [URL]

Delivery Date: [Date]

Built by: [Your Name / The Analyst Agenda]

LOGIN DETAILS

Vercel: [link] — [their email]

Google Search Console: [link] — [their Google account]

Google Analytics: [link] — [their Google account]

Google Business Profile: [link] — [their Google account]

Contact Form: Formspree — [link] — [email receiving form submissions]

Domain registrar: [where domain is registered, their login]

HOW TO UPDATE YOUR WEBSITE

To update text or images on your website, send the changes to:

[your email] and we will action within [X] business days.

[Optional: If handing over full control]

Your website code is on GitHub at: [URL]

You can hire any web developer to make changes using this codebase.

WHAT'S INCLUDED

- ✓ Fully responsive website ([X] pages)
- ✓ Contact form connected to your email
- ✓ Google Analytics — track your visitors
- ✓ Google Search Console — monitor search performance
- ✓ SSL certificate (HTTPS) — your site is secure
- ✓ sitemap.xml submitted to Google
- ✓ Local Business schema markup for Google visibility
- ✓ Mobile-optimised for all devices

WHAT YOU OWN

- Your domain name (registered in your name, ~\$20/year to renew)
- Your Google accounts and all data within them
- Your website codebase (available on request)

WHAT IS FREE

- Hosting: \$0/month (Vercel free tier)
- SSL: \$0
- Analytics: \$0
- Search Console: \$0

YOUR NEXT STEPS

1. Start posting on Google Business Profile regularly (photos, updates)
2. Ask satisfied customers to leave Google reviews

3. Share your new website on social media

SUPPORT

For website updates or questions: [your email]

Response time: [X] business days

Step 8.4 — Handover Call

Book a 30-minute video call to:

- Walk the client through the live website
 - Show them how to check Google Analytics
 - Show them where form submissions appear in their inbox
 - Explain what they own versus what you manage
 - Collect the final 50% payment (Stripe link)
-

PHASE 9 — COLLECTING FINAL PAYMENT

1. Send a Stripe payment link for the remaining 50% before or during the handover call
 2. Do not hand over login credentials until payment is confirmed
 3. Issue a simple invoice via Stripe (automatic when payment completes)
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PHASE 10 — OPTIONAL UPSELLS

Present these at the handover call or within the first month after delivery.

Upsell A — Google Ads Management

Pitch: "Your website is live and indexed by Google. The fastest way to start getting enquiries right now is Google Ads — we can have your first campaign live within 48 hours."

What you deliver:

- Google Ads account setup
- Keyword research for their service area and industry
- 2–3 ad groups with 3–5 ads each
- Conversion tracking connected to the contact form

- Monthly performance report

Tools:

- Google Ads (ads.google.com) — free to use, client pays ad spend
- Google Keyword Planner — free research tool within Google Ads
- Google Analytics linked to Ads for conversion data

Pricing: \$200–\$500 NZD/month management fee + client's ad spend budget (recommend starting at \$300–\$500 NZD/month ad spend)

Upsell B — Advanced SEO Package

Pitch: "Your site is already optimised for the basics. An advanced SEO package gets you ranking above competitors for the searches that matter most to your business."

What you deliver:

- Keyword research report (top 20 target keywords)
- Competitor gap analysis
- On-page optimisation for top 5 keywords
- 3–5 additional blog posts targeting long-tail keywords
- Google Search Console monitoring for 3 months with monthly report

Tools:

- Google Search Console — free
- Google Keyword Planner — free
- Ubersuggest (free tier) — keyword ideas
- Google Trends — free

Pricing: \$400–\$800 NZD one-time, or \$150–\$300 NZD/month for ongoing content

QUICK REFERENCE — BUILD SEQUENCE SUMMARY

1. Signed brief + 50% deposit received
2. Set up project in VS Code + Claude Code
3. Run: `npx create-next-app@latest`

4. Master prompt into Claude Code
5. Build pages one by one, preview at localhost:3000
6. Add images, contact form (Formspree), copy
7. SEO baseline: titles, meta, schema, sitemap
8. QA checklist — fix all issues
9. Lighthouse score check
10. Git push to GitHub
11. Connect GitHub to Vercel → auto-deploy
12. Send .vercel.app preview to client
13. Client approves → connect custom domain
14. Set up Google Search Console + Google Analytics
15. Handover document sent
16. 30-min handover call
17. Final 50% payment collected
18. Optional: pitch Google Ads / Advanced SEO upsell

TROUBLESHOOTING

Problem	Fix
Site not loading after domain connected	DNS propagation — wait up to 48 hours
Contact form not sending	Check Formspree account, confirm endpoint URL is correct

Problem	Fix
Lighthouse score below 80	Ask Claude Code: "Improve performance: reduce image sizes, remove unused imports, add lazy loading"
Google Search Console not verifying	Confirm the TXT record was added to DNS correctly
Mobile layout broken	Describe the issue to Claude Code with the screen size and element affected
Client wants changes after handover	Scope a change request; charge a flat fee per session (\$100–\$200 NZD) or a retainer

Document maintained by The Analyst Agenda. Update version number and date when revised.